

Lesson 1: Where We Are

Teacher Guide · Middle and High School

This lesson introduces a real Mississippi case: the death of 18-year-old Nolan Xavier Wells in July 2026 and a grand jury's decision not to bring charges. Students learn which offices handle a death investigation, key legal vocabulary, and the legal paths that remain open. The focus is how the system works, not who is to blame.

01 At a glance

Time	One 40 to 50 minute class period.
Video	Lesson 1: Where We Are, about 2 minutes, from the Nolan Xavier Wells School of Law series by Agent Kodak (@AgentKodak on YouTube, TikTok, Instagram and Facebook).
Materials	Student Guide (Middle or High School), the video, and optional devices for the interactive map (QR code on each guide).
Students will	• Identify five offices involved in a death investigation and describe each one's job. • Define grand jury, no true bill, autopsy and undetermined. • Explain why a "no true bill" is different from a "not guilty" verdict. • Tell the difference between a verified fact, an official's statement and a claim.
Standards	Fits civics and government standards on the justice system, the roles of public officials, citizen participation and evaluating sources (for example, the civics and inquiry strands of the C3 Framework). Match it to your state's standards.

02 Before you teach

- This is the real death of a teenager. His family is still grieving. Keep the focus on how the system works.
- The video contains no graphic images. Avoid searching for or showing any.
- Do not name or speculate about private people connected to the case, including the friends who were with him. If students bring up names or rumors from social media, redirect them to verified sources.
- Keep discussion nonpartisan. No candidates or parties.
- Some students may have lost someone. Offer a quiet option and check in.
- Agent Kodak is an educator, not an attorney. Nothing here is legal advice.

03 Lesson flow

Step	Minutes	What happens
Warm-up	5	Ask: "When someone dies unexpectedly, who decides what happened?" List student guesses on the board.
Watch	5	Play the video once straight through. Play it again while students fill in Section 01.
Guide	15	Students complete Sections 02 and 03 in pairs.
Map	10	Students scan the QR code and tap the lit-up offices for Lesson 1. Check Section 03 answers against the map.
Discuss	10	Use one or two prompts from Section 07.
Exit	5	Section 05 exit ticket.

04 Answer key: Watch and fill in

#	Middle School	High School
1	Horn	no true bill
2	grand jury	132; 43
3	charges	undetermined
4	subpoenas	stomach
5	determined	discovery
6	limit	statute of limitations (time limit)

05 Answer key: Vocabulary

Middle School matching: Autopsy = D · Grand jury = A · Undetermined = F · No true bill = B · Medical examiner = E · Evidence = C

High School term	Sample definition
Grand jury	Citizens who meet in private to decide whether there is probable cause to charge someone. In Mississippi, 12 must agree.
No true bill	A grand jury decision not to charge. It is not a "not guilty" verdict; the case can return with new evidence.
Indictment	A formal criminal charge voted by a grand jury.
Subpoena	A court order to hand over evidence or come testify.
Autopsy	A medical examination after death to find the cause and manner of death.
Manner of death	How a death happened: natural, accident, suicide, homicide or undetermined.
Statute of limitations	A legal time limit for bringing charges. Mississippi has none for murder.
Civil lawsuit	A case where one side sues another for money or a court order, with a lower proof bar than a criminal case.

06 Answer key: Who does what?

Position	Responsibility	How they get the job
Sheriff	Investigates deaths outside city limits and gathers the evidence others will review.	Elected by county voters
Coroner	Opens the death investigation and decides whether an autopsy is needed.	Elected by county voters (needs a high school diploma and short training)
State Medical Examiner	The doctor who performs the autopsy and decides the cause and manner of death.	Appointed by the state Commissioner of Public Safety
District Attorney (DA)	Decides whether to seek charges and presents the case to the grand jury.	Elected by voters in the district
Grand Jury	Citizens who decide in private whether there is enough evidence to charge someone. 12 must agree.	Chosen at random from voter rolls and driver's license records

07 Discussion prompts

- Why do you think Mississippi lets regular citizens, not a judge, decide whether to charge someone?
- What's the difference between "we don't know yet" and "nothing happened"?
- How should we treat information about a real case that we see on social media?
- Most of these officials are elected. What power does that give your community?

08 Research assignments (use the map)

- Office profile: pick one office on the map. Who holds it, how did they get the job, when is the next election, and what do they control? Cite the source.
- Timeline: open "Timeline + gaps" on the map. List three verified events and one gap, and explain why the gap matters.
- Local connection: find out who handles death investigations in your own county. Is it a coroner or a medical examiner? Elected or appointed?
- Civic letter: write a respectful letter to an elected official asking one question about transparency. Teacher reviews before anything is sent.

09 Differentiation

- Middle school: read key lines aloud, allow the word bank, and pair students for Section 03.
- English learners: preview the vocabulary with pictures (a jury box, a courthouse, a doctor) before the video.
- Advanced: read Mississippi Code 99-1-5 and explain in your own words why it matters to this case.



Learn more on your own time

Scan to open the interactive map for Lesson 1. Tap the lit-up offices, hover the i terms, read the sources and take the quiz.

lawrencetotimeh.com/class/#lesson1

Sources for this lesson: Mississippi Today (Sept. 21 and 24, 2026); Jackson County Grand Jury Report (filed Sept. 18, 2026); Miss. Code 99-1-5 (no time limit on murder); Miss. Code 19-21-103 (coroner qualifications); Miss. Code 41-61-55 (State Medical Examiner).